THE LETTERS OF THE RAMBAM

# Not Random, Not in the Stars: Providence & Suffering

Letter on Astrology, Part 2

**Source:** Igrot HaRambam: the Letter to the Sages of Montpellier on Astrology (c. 1194–95), second half

**Shiur:** Third class in the series on the Rambam's letters, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 4 February 2025

*These notes are based on the Sofer.ai transcript of the recording.*

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## Recap of Part 1

- The letter (1194 or 1195), the Rambam's first to Provence, in **Hebrew**, to the sages of Montpellier and **Rabbi Yonatan HaKohen of Lunel**, a Tosafist and staunch defender of the Rambam.
- **Three sources of knowledge**: reason, the senses, tradition (as Rav Saadiah said 200 years earlier). Uncritical acceptance of whatever is written is "a great illness."
- Belief in astrology **cost us our sovereignty and the Temple**.
- **"Don't reject astrology because there are no proofs *for* it; reject it because there are proofs *against* it."**
- He read every book on paganism and found reasons for mitzvot (sha'atnez, meat and milk, pe'ot, the razor).
- **Astronomy** is "an exceptional science"; **astrology** is a pseudo-science.

The **Mishneh Torah** says it all in one halacha (Avodah Zarah 11:16):

> **ודברים האלו כולן דברי שקר וכזב הן... וכל המאמין בדברים האלו וכיוצא בהן, ומחשב בליבו שהן אמת ודבר חכמה אבל התורה מנעה אותן, אינן אלא מן הסכלים ומחסרי הדעת... אבל בעלי החכמה ותמימי הדעת ידעו בראיות ברורות שכל אלו הדברים... אינם דברי חכמה אלא תוהו והבל**

These are all lies... Whoever believes in them and thinks **they're true and wise, only the Torah forbade them**, is among the fools. The wise know **by clear proofs** that they are not wisdom but emptiness.

(Elsewhere he adds "and women and children, whose minds are not complete," reflecting a time when women were far less educated than men.)

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## Part 1: Three Views of Creation

Everyone in the Rambam's day, philosophers included, **believed in a Creator**, "basically the case until relatively recently." The debate was **how the universe came about**:

| | View | Whose |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | The world is **eternal**, never began and never ends, co-existing with God | **Aristotle** ("the majority") |
| 2 | God **created** the world, but from **eternal unformed matter** (*hylē*, *chomer*) that always existed alongside Him; even God can't make something from nothing. (In the *Moreh*: one day it will return to that matter) | **Plato**; the **Ibn Ezra** on Bereishit seems to hold it |
| 3 | God created everything **from absolutely nothing** | **The prophets and our tradition** (a minority of philosophers, the *Moreh* says) |

"Thousands of books" argue each view; the *Moreh* says the debate is at least **3,000 years old**, so 4,000 by now. The Monday class saw Rav Saadiah's **thirteen** views of creation and his refutation of Plato a year ago.

**He doesn't name Aristotle or Plato here.** The sages of Provence didn't have Golden-Age Spain's exposure to philosophy, so naming them "wouldn't be appreciated."

### The Rambam here vs. in the *Moreh*

**Here** he's unequivocal: **you must believe the third view; deny it and you've denied a fundamental.** He wrote a whole book in Arabic (the *Moreh*) proving God's existence, explaining anthropomorphic verses as metaphor, **dismantling the proofs for eternity**, and **answering** the question "how can something come from nothing?"

**Note the wording:** he *dismantled* the case for eternity and *answered the questions*. He doesn't claim to have **proved** creation from nothing. In the *Moreh* he says explicitly that he can't prove it.

**A theme of the letters: the Rambam writes for his recipient.** In the **Moreh (II:25)** he rejects Aristotle outright but is **far more sympathetic to Plato**. He concludes for creation from nothing, but doesn't treat Plato's view as heresy, and some Rishonim held it. That same chapter famously says: **if Aristotle had been proven**, "I'd have no problem reinterpreting 'In the beginning God created' allegorically," as he does with the hundreds of anthropomorphic verses. "That's not my problem. His proofs aren't good enough." **"We will see this over and over again**, especially in the Letter to Yemen."

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## Part 2: What All Three Agree On

### Intermediaries: the "trickle-down"

All three views agree **God acts through intermediaries**: the spheres and stars, through which His energy *(shefa)* flows down to create and sustain plants, animals and minerals. **The Rambam accepts this**: "it does not conflict with our tradition; the Sages believed it too," as he shows in the *Moreh*.

- In the *Moreh*: **ten** levels; each of nine spheres has an associated **intelligence**, and the tenth, the **Active Intellect**, governs the lowest realm, our world.

means מלאך. **aren't "angels."** That translation came from our exposure to Christianity **מלאכים**
In the Rambam they are incorporeal. **וישלח יעקב מלאכים**: **messenger, emissary, agent**
.intelligences through which the flow passes

- **A participant asked:** what about Gavriel, Michael and Raphael, who came to Avraham? (The Rabbi noted that Daniel, also suggested, is not an angel at all.) The names exist **to give an identity** to the different intermediaries: like **one sunlight** seen through different coloured glasses.

### Free will

All three also agree **a person's actions are in his own hands**: serve Hashem and study, or follow the wicked into adultery and theft. Nothing pulls him either way. That's why the Torah commands at all. (The Rambam refers to his Arabic writings, the **Eight Chapters**.)

### Where we part company: *what happens to us*

All three philosophical views agree **what happens to a person is chance**: neither God nor the stars decide it.

To them, there's **no difference** between a lion eating a man and a cat eating a mouse; a man falling off a roof and a stone breaking a branch; **armies fighting** and **dogs fighting over a carcass**. All chance.

**We reject that. There is justice.** Hashem watches every human action.

If you walk with Me **by chance**..., I will walk with you in" :**ואם תלכו עמי קרי... והלכתי עמכם בחמת קרי**
the fury of chance." If you say, when bad things happen, "it's just random," **I'll leave you to .randomness**

**Suffering comes only through sin.**

### Two important points

1. **For the Rambam, providence covers humans only** (and what affects them). The lions and cheetahs on *National Geographic* really are random. His complaint about the philosophers is that they **lump humans in with nature**.
2. **The taxi analogy:** a man with 100 identical taxis retiring to keep only 10 sells the first 90 that come to hand. He cares that **ten remain** (general providence over a species), not *which* ten. Ownerless sheep are like that. A farmer's 100 sheep, by contrast, come under providence **because he does**.
3. **Treat life as random, and it becomes random.** Providence is withdrawn and you're left to exist like an animal: you may prosper as a lion prospers, but you're left to chance.

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## Part 3: Reuven the Tanner and Shimon the Spice-Merchant

**Reuven** is a poor tanner whose children died; **Shimon** a wealthy perfumer with lovely children. Three explanations:

| | Why? | Can it change? |
|---|---|---|
| **The philosophers** | **Chance** | Yes, randomly |
| **The astrologers** ("whom you've been hearing in France") | **The stars** decree it | Not while the stars say so |
| **Our faith** | **Hashem's will**, which responds to **their actions** | **At any moment.** If Shimon sins he'll become poor; if Reuven mends his ways, all will be good |

Both alternatives fail **logically** (astrology has been disproved) and **religiously**: if life were random or star-fixed, **what would the Torah's laws be for?**

### "But I don't see it that way"

The Rambam covers this in one sentence: when someone improves and things don't change, there is **a backlog of sin** still to be paid, or (he adds) **suffering to earn a greater share in the World to Come**. "We can't always understand how Hashem works."

**A subtlety:** two weeks ago on Monday the class saw **Rav Saadiah** teach that suffering can increase one's share in Olam HaBa. **The Rambam doesn't hold that**; in the *Moreh* he follows **אין יסורין בלא עוון**, no suffering without sin. So the editor, **Rav Shilat**, says that here the Rambam is **citing others' view**, not his own. "Difficult, I accept, but consistent." The point is simply: **there is a reason.**

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## Part 4: What About the Talmud's Astrology?

The question from last week. The Gemara (Shabbat 156) devotes half a page to it: born on **Sunday**, all one thing or another; **Monday**, angry; **Tuesday**, wealthy and promiscuous; **Wednesday**, wise; **Thursday**, kind; then by planet: **Mars** sheds blood, and so on.

I know you'll find in the **Talmud and Midrashim** statements of individual sages that seem to say the stars determine a person's fate. **Don't let it trouble you.** It isn't right to **abandon a law that is logical and proven**, wash your hands of it, and rely on a single sage's statement...

**"Where did we see almost these exact words? Two weeks ago"**: the letter to Ovadia, about the Gemara that **marriages are decreed** forty days before birth. Don't abandon the roots for one or two statements.

### Three explanations

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | **The matter was hidden from him**: that sage **was mistaken** | can mean *from him* or *from us*. Some, uncomfortable, read it as **ממנו** "hidden from **us**." "It shows how, because of personal feeling, people will reinterpret things." The Rabbi reads it as the sage himself missing something |
| 2 | **He meant something deeper**, hinted, metaphorical | |
| 3 | **He was responding to a situation** | E.g. **Rava**: "life, children and livelihood depend on *mazal*, not merit." He saw two equally pious sages, **Rabbah and Rav Chisda**, one with a hard life, one a good one |

**Like zugot:** the Gemara warns against doing things **in pairs**. "Nobody does this any more," though some do with eggs, and the **S&P** calls only an **odd number of aliyot** when adding extras (an eighth means calling a ninth too, then 11, 13, 15). **Rav Moshe Feinstein** wrote that such warnings apply **to those who believe in them**. Similarly, some say **ayin hara** has power only if you let it; the Rambam, the Rabbi thinks, didn't believe in it at all. "Sometimes we do that as rabbis too": people say things we don't believe, and "we don't want to shake their faith, so we give it a religious touch."

If we interpret **Torah verses** metaphorically, **all the more so** a few Rabbinic statements.

**ואל ישליך אדם דעתו אחריו, כי העיניים לפנים הם ולא לאחור: don't throw your intelligence behind you; your eyes are in front, not behind.**

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## Part 5: A False Mashiach, and the Signature

**They'd heard of a false Mashiach in Isfahan.** No, says the Rambam: you mixed it up. It was in **Yemen**, about **22 years earlier**: a man claiming to be the Mashiach's herald, gathering Jews and Arabs, changing the prayers, said to work miracles. His students asked him how to relate to it.

I wrote that **he means well but is a fool**, that it was all falsehood, and that I feared for the Jews when the government found out. A year later he was caught. The Arab king asked for proof. "**Cut off my head and I'll live.**" "Fine. If you're right, I'll convert." **He was killed. תהא מיתתו כפרה לו ולכל ישראל.** The Jews were **fined** in many places, and **there are still fools there who say he'll rise again**.

(A "second Jesus." Much more on this in the Letter to Yemen.)

**The close:**

Uproot **the thorns and poisonous weeds**; plant in their place **the tree of the knowledge of good and evil**; eat its fruit and enjoy it... May Hashem let us and you be satisfied from His goodness forever.

**Written under great pressure, on the 11th of Tishrei**, in Egypt.

"The day after Yom Kippur! He didn't spend it recovering." And: **"Forgive my terseness; I'm so busy working for the gentiles."** A later letter describes his schedule: busy at the **Sultan's**

**palace** from Shabbat to Shabbat, studying only on Shabbat. He only replied because his friend **Rav Pinchas** sent a messenger with orders **not to leave until the Rambam wrote**.

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## Part 6: Others Disagree

**Most Rishonim disagreed with the Rambam**: the **Ramban**, **Sefer HaChinuch**, **Meiri**, **Ralbag** held astrology is a **real** science.

- **The Ramban:** don't seek out astrologers, but if you hear something from one, **don't ignore it**; don't rely on a miracle: take care and **increase prayer**.

- **The Vilna Gaon** famously writes sharply against the Rambam: so many Talmudic passages speak of mazal and magic, but **"philosophy led him astray,"** and he explained the Talmud metaphorically, uprooting its simple meaning. The Gaon says there are deeper meanings, but Kabbalistic, not philosophical.

- **With the Rambam: Ibn Pakuda** and others before him likewise held astrology to be futile.

**Robert** asked: astrologers say your *circumstances* are set, but surely not your *reactions*? Reward and punishment could still work. The **Ran** and others who accept astrology say it gives only a **tendency** ("born under Mars, you tend toward blood; you can control it, but it's harder"). The Rambam himself says something similar about **character** in the **Eight Chapters**: one can be born with a tendency. But to attribute that to the **stars** "is too much: too much destiny." A participant suggested the Rambam might allow it as a variable, and the Rabbi agreed that is **the majority view of the Sages**, though not the Rambam's. "The Rambam was an outlier on this point. Each person needs to make their own choices whom they follow."

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## Part 7: So What Does "Mazal Tov" Mean?

"Good luck," everyone says. **But we just spent two weeks saying luck is nonsense!**

1. **The Rambam would never have said it.** "I really can't believe he would have."
2. Read **מזל** literally as **flow**, from **נוזל**: *may your actions bring down a good flow***. That fits the "trickle-down" he does accept.
3. Most people just mean **congratulations**.

**The Shulchan Aruch** forbids consulting astrologers and superstitions (Yoreh De'ah 179), then **in the next halacha** records the custom not to **begin things on Mondays and Wednesdays** and to **marry when the moon is waxing**. Isn't that superstition? No: it's a **סימן**, a sign.

That's why **Sephardim** traditionally say **בסימן טוב**, or **בסימנא טבא** (as at the end of the Torah reading cycle). **It doesn't mean good luck; it means starting on the right foot.**

The **Meiri** on the Rosh Hashanah foods: **don't be stupid and think** eating a date or an apple *brings* you a good year. A *siman* sets your **frame of mind**.

**The practical takeaway:** if you accept the Rambam, wish people **"b'siman tov"**, or if you say "mazal tov," mean *a good flow*.

"It would be interesting to research when 'mazal tov' came into use. It can't be very long ago."

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## Summary

1. **Creation**: three views (Aristotle, Plato, creation from nothing). The Rambam insists here on the third, more sharply than in the *Moreh*, because **he writes for his audience**.
2. All agree God works through **intermediaries** (spheres, intelligences; *mal'achim* are messengers) and that humans have **free will**.
3. **But** philosophers say what happens to us is **chance**, astrologers say it is **fixed by the stars**. **Judaism says it is just**, responsive to our deeds, and can change at any moment. Treat life as random and it will be.
4. **Providence** in the Rambam covers humans, not animals as individuals.
5. **Talmudic astrology**: the sage erred, spoke in hints, or answered a situation. **Your eyes are in front, not behind.**
6. Most Rishonim (Ramban, Chinuch, Meiri, Ralbag, later the Vilna Gaon) disagree; the Rambam is an outlier.
7. Say **"b'siman tov."**

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## Coming Up

**Next week:** the **Letter on Martyrdom** (*Iggeret HaShmad*).

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